AADHAAR ROLLOUT, 2009

# Giving Citizens an Identity

**The world's largest biometric ID system, Aadhaar has streamlined welfare delivery, leading to financial inclusion and security**

BY M.G. ARUN

The establishment of the Unique Identification Authority of India (UIDAI) in 2009 marked a watershed moment in the country's digital and governance landscape. At its core was Aadhaar, a 12-digit unique identification number for India's teeming population designed to consolidate identity verification into a single, robust system, integrating biometric and demographic data. Today, Aadhaar stands as the world's largest biometric ID system, revolutionising how government welfare reaches citizens.

The initial vision for Aadhaar took shape during the United Progressive Alliance (UPA) government led by prime minister Manmohan Singh. The intent was clear: eliminate duplicate and fake identities making identity verification easy and cost-effective, thus enabling targeted delivery of social and welfare schemes. Nandan Nilekani, co-founder of Infosys, was handpicked to lead the UIDAI.

**1.38 BILLION**
**Total number of Aadhaar cards in India as of Oct. 2024**



**THE HI-TECH PUSH**
A file photo of UIDAI founding chairman Nandan Nilekani

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